

Another Lok Sabha member, Sambasiva Rayapati Rao (Congress), with interests in tobacco and the construction sector, sought the Government views on the hybrid model in highway projects, which allows concessionaires to collect toll. On another day, the tobacco industry took priority, when he wanted to know whether the Central Tobacco Research Institute is exploring "the beneficial uses of tobacco".

Some members are participating in parliamentary debates, raising questions and enjoying membership of the all-powerful committees without giving the nation much chance to know about their personal interests. Parliament debates make many wonder whether the members are

pursuing their own businesses rather than issues of national interest. The conflict of interest is difficult to detect without a strong parliamentary mechanism to define interests and oversee the growing number of legislators with business interests.

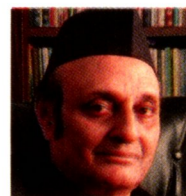
Parliamentary committees are where the real "conflict" can take place. The 31-member Standing Committee on Finance is virtually an industry who's who—venture capitalist Rajeev Chandrasekhar (Independent) from Karnataka, chief-minister-hopeful of Andhra Pradesh and business magnate Y.S. Jaganmohan Reddy (Congress), Maharashtra-based industrialist Vijay Jawaharlal Darda (Congress), Sambasiva Rayapati and industrialist Magunta

Tamil Nadu educationist M. Thambi Durai (AIADMK).

Parliamentary committees are not just talking shops. The Standing Committee system is a path-breaking endeavour of parliamentary surveillance over administration and it may even include high-ranking officials from the executive. The Standing Committee on Health has at least three members who run medical education institutions—Prabhakar B. Kore, the BJP MP from Karnataka, is chairman of the Karnataka Lingayat Education Society, which runs 18 medical science institutions; MAM Ramaswamy of the Janata Dal(S), Rajya Sabha member from Karnataka, is pro-chancellor of the Annamalai University, which also has

“ Conflict of interest is a developing situation. It has not become embedded in procedures. There should be a mechanism to encourage the members to declare their interests. ”

KARAN SINGH, *Chairman, Ethics Committee*



Srinivasulu Reddy (Congress) from Andhra Pradesh. The 26-member Standing Committee on Industry has Uttar Pradesh businessman Akhilesh Das (BSP) as its chairperson; perfume baron Badruddin Ajmal (AUDF) and Andhra Pradesh textile manufacturer Gireesh Kumar Sanghi (Congress) are its members. Over a third of the members of the committee on industry—nine out of 26—are from business and industry. The Public Accounts Committee boasts of members like industrialist Navin Jindal (Congress), Andhra Pradesh-based contractor Kavuri Sambasiva Rao (Congress) and

medical institutions, including a medical college, and Wardha's Congress MP Datta Raghobaji Meghe is the president of the Radhikabai Meghe Memorial Medical Trust that manages a deemed university, the Datta Meghe Institute of Medical Sciences.

The 21-member Committee on Public Undertakings (COPU) has eight businessmen as its members. The committee came under the scanner when it summoned the authorities of the NHAI and sought an explanation about its working. Incidentally, three of its members—T. Subbirami Reddy (Congress), Nageswara (TDP) and



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The number of MPs in the present House who are industrialists and businessmen is 100—double the number in the first Lok Sabha.

Only 212 of the 250 Rajya Sabha members have listed their interests. The Lok Sabha does not even maintain such a record.

Unlike in many other democracies, there is NO mechanism to monitor members' conflict of interest on a day-to-day basis.